

The hardest balance

In a sport where stillness is everything, Meghana Sajjanar **had to fight** movement from within. Eight months pregnant, the 32-year-old won bronze in the women's 10m air rifle to claim her first individual medal at the Asian Shooting Championships.

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Competing in the women's 10m air rifle event at the Asian Shooting Championships earlier this month, Meghana Sajjanar didn't get the start she would have wanted in qualification. She shot a relatively average first series (shooters fire six series of 10 shots each) of 103.2, and at that point was placed 18th in the 29-shooter field.

Meghana knew right away what the problem was. Fixing it, though, wasn't entirely up to her. The 32-year-old was competing while eight months pregnant, and her baby had chosen the most unfortunate time to make its presence felt. "Perhaps it was due to the anxiety level I was under when I started the match. But right as the qualification round started, my baby started to kick!" she would tell Sportstar later.

Few sports test balance and precision as much as 10m air rifle shooting. Building a solid base is hard enough. Doing it while trying to steady tremors and aim at a bullseye 0.5 mm across is harder still, especially with an enormous baby bump. And when that baby decided it was time to start moving, Meghana knew exactly what she was up against.

"I was like, OK! This isn't great. Since it's precision, even a little movement makes a huge difference on the target. And there was a lot of movement from the baby. I

had to be calm and relaxed, and I told the baby to stay quiet as well!" she says. The baby, she says, was only partly cooperative. "The baby wasn't quiet for the rest of the series, so I had to cancel a lot of shots," she says.

Meghana had to pick her shots. She did more than that. She shot strongly in her remaining five series and made the finals in fifth place (the top eight go through). In the final, she fired just one shot outside the 10-ring. It was enough for bronze, her first individual medal at the Asian Championships.

Only after the competition ended did Meghana explain what the medal meant to her. "So, it's a really different, a very special experience to be in the eighth month of pregnancy and shooting. It's easily the most memorable medal I've ever won," says Meghana, who is due to give birth in early March.

Meghana turned heads when she lined up at the firing line. Her accomplishment drew praise on social media, including from badminton star P.V. Sindhu. Initially,